

Djokovic, twice his age at 36 and playing his 410th Grand Slam match, said in his post-match press conference. "For an 18-year-old, he played so maturely and confidently on the court, fighting through, not giving up even when he was four down in the fourth set. Impressed with his mentality, with his approach, with his game."

DINO PRIZMIC DISPLAYED GUTS AND GRIT WHEN HE STAVED OFF FOUR MATCH POINTS AGAINST THE BEST SERVE RETURNER IN TENNIS HISTORY

Winning big points is another auspicious sign for Prizmic, who celebrated them with a 'Mr. T' scowl. Fearless shot-making gave him the second set tiebreaker 7-5 against Djokovic, who had racked up a superb 17-2 tiebreaker record at majors last year. The Croat again displayed guts and grit when he staved off four match points against the best serve returner in tennis history to hold in the penultimate game of the final set.

Djokovic noted their "grueling rallies, very physical games. Almost four hours for four sets." Then he paid Prizmic the ultimate compliment: "It felt at some point I was playing myself in a mirror already."

Not surprisingly, the hyper-competitive Prizmic enjoys the Ultimate Fighting Championship (UFC). His favourite athlete, after Djokovic, is Kamaru Usman, the Nigerian-American former UFC Welterweight Champion and The Ultimate Fighter 21 tournament winner.

Although Prizmic, who upset No. 30 Jiri Lehecka and No. 81 Tomas Machac at the Stockholm Open last

October, says his forehand is his favorite shot, Djokovic praised his backhand. "I hear that he liked to watch me when he was growing up. He's got an incredible defence, especially from the backhand side. Very all-round game. Of course, he's got every shot in the game [still] to improve."

On the teenager's rugged 6'2", 180-pound physique, fitness fanatic Djokovic noted, "I think I'm most impressed with his physical state for

there not with a desire to just play a nice set or enjoy the experience, but rather to win. Kudos to him. It was impressive. If he continues this way, he's going to have a very bright career ahead of him, no doubt."

Who will be the next great American men's player?

In the 20th century, this question conveyed optimism. That was when the U.S. produced champions with such regularity that we thought its domination would never end. But suddenly and shockingly, it did. All-time great Pete Sampras's 14th and last Grand Slam title at the 2002 US Open and Andy Roddick's only major title at the 2003 US Open were followed by an unforeseen, almost unimaginable drought.

The legendary Big Three — Roger Federer, Rafael Nadal, and Novak Djokovic — ruled the men's game for the next 20 years. And now Carlos Alcaraz and Jannik Sinner are poised to dominate the rest of this decade.

Today this question is seldom asked. The more attainable goal is making the top 10, excellence to be sure, but not greatness. Currently,

Primed for attack: Prizmic has made a name for himself with his fearless shot-making and tested Novak Djokovic for four hours in their Australian Open encounter. GETTY IMAGES

